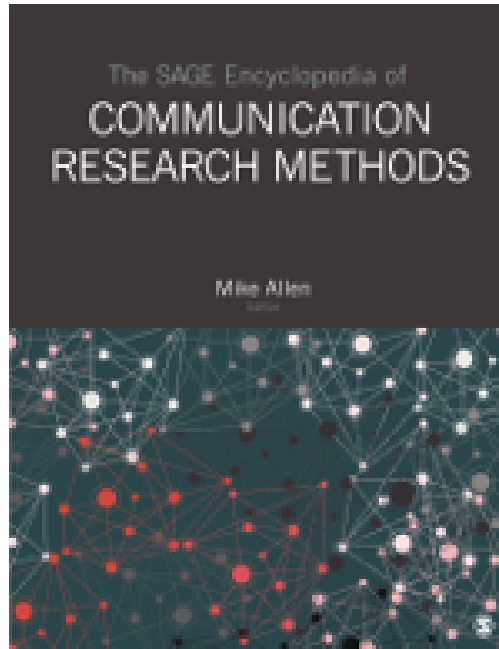




Sage Research Methods

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Author: Mark A. Leeman, David R. Novak

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The term *qualitative data* is simply defined as information that is expressed in natural language and therefore is not conveyed, or is easily reduced or summed up, by numbers. The term *data* may not be fully embraced by some qualitative researchers due to its historical association with quantitative or numerical ways of knowing. The modifying adjective *qualitative* seems to be needed when used with *data*, whereas the phrase *quantitative data* is rare and seems redundant. Because of this bias, qualitative researchers often prefer terms such as *discourse*, *language*, or *information* over the use of *data*. If, however, we take the word *data* from its original Latin roots to mean “something given,” or simply “pieces of information,” then we can more freely discuss what that might mean for qualitative research. The “qual” in *qualitative* comes from the root meaning of *qualities*, which is in the sense of properties characteristics, or the “nature of” something. Therefore, when we look at qualitative data, we are looking at pieces of information that give us insight into the qualities of communication, meanings, language, social interactions, and the like. These pieces of information are not numbers (that would be *quantitative*—meaning the “quantity” or count of something), but rather chunks of language, discourse, and meanings symbolized in a variety of ways (but that exclude statistical sums).

Whether the research is interpretive or critical in nature (those being the dominant forms of qualitative inquiry), the overarching goal of collecting and examining qualitative data is to better understand the meanings held by participants, and to dig into the processes, rules, and categories that their meaning management seems to follow and fall into. In pursuit of those goals, qualitative data is typically collected in one of three ways: (1) *observations*: directly observing communication and interaction in the environment in which it occurs; (2) *questions and answers*: the use of interviews and/or surveys to ask questions of participants to elicit their perspectives and meanings; and (3) *document and/or textual analysis*: researchers analyzing texts that have been previously recorded and often are available in the public realm. The three ways of qualitative data collection are discussed in greater detail in the following sections.

Observations

Observing social interaction in its natural context, and in its natural language, arguably yields the “purest” of all qualitative data. “Pure” in the sense that it is in real time, is real-world communication, and is being done by the real people that are of interest to the research. This sort of data, however, must still be gathered (which includes choosing what to include and what to leave out) and interpreted by the researcher. Observations are usually combined with interviews and textual analysis to help balance out strengths and weaknesses of each.

When observing any “scene” for qualitative inquiry, the positioning of the researcher is a key consideration. Qualitative observers may just observe as guests on the sideline of interactions, they may be participants at some level in the activities being studied (such as volunteering for an organization being investigated), they may be an activist or action researcher that creates the context being studied, or they may be a natural and

historical insider that is now in the role of researcher of that native (to them) context. No matter what the positioning of the data gatherers, they engage in real-time interaction in its natural context, and usually for extended periods of time, in order to understand what is occurring in the situation being observed.

Questions and Answers

Because of familiarity with interviewing gained through consumption of journalistic inquiry, one's mind may go first and foremost to this form of gathering qualitative data. There is no doubt that interviews, in one form or another, are mainstays for gathering qualitative research information. Interviews elicit participants' experiences, interpretations, and understandings in their own words via their stories, accounts, and recollections. Although the data collected may not be exactly in the "raw" native form in which the language or meanings were used in the original experience, at least the words are coming directly from participants. This helps researchers by making available to them access to events and sensemaking that it would be impossible to observe directly.

One important way that interviews vary is according to the extent they are controlled by the interviewer. Highly structured interviews that strictly follow an interview protocol or script may be needed when multiple interviewers are used, and when consistency is a must. Less controlled, and very popular in qualitative research, is the semi-structured interview, in which space is allowed for a more conversational and collaborative style that allows the interaction to go in natural directions—especially as led by the interviewee. This allows participants to emphasize what is most important to them, and gives them the freedom (from tightly directed questions) to interpret the general questions in their own manner and answer more as they see fit. Many researchers feel this allows them to collect more authentic qualitative data. Feminist and postcolonial scholars have also called for more radically open styles of gathering information from participants that take even more control out of the hands of the "expert" researcher and put the locus of control more on the side of the native speaker being interviewed. Creative ways to elicit stories and perspectives may vary from just asking for "a story that gets at how you felt about x," to asking participants to rearrange artifacts (even bones have been used) in the manner of traditional storytelling. In such interviews, listening and reflecting on participants' communication is valued above steering things in the researcher's pre-chosen (a priori) directions.

Focus groups are group interviews that bring the added dimension of adding some natural context (they are speaking with other peers) into the interview process. Sometimes others in the group will empower participants to lose inhibitions and think and speak more frankly and openly. The flip side is that group dynamics add much complexity, and may affect what a participant feels comfortable conveying.

Finally, surveys are another important ways that qualitative researchers ask questions and gather data.

Closed-ended survey questions (such as those that demand participants choose one of four or five pre-written responses) are a mainstay of quantitative research because they serve as a useful way to turn qualitative meanings (questions written in words) into numeric values used for computation. Surveys, however, can also be an important source of qualitative data. Survey questions start out in natural language and the results can be kept in that form and analyzed. Surveys may also contain opened-ended questions that allow the respondents to reply in their own words.

Document and Textual Analysis

Often there is much recorded information about a phenomenon, interaction, or context already in existence before a researcher begins inquiry. All that public or private discourse, whether it be written, filmed, or captured and stored in some other form, is valuable qualitative data offering insights and examples surrounding the questions being investigated. For instance, often when (or before) studying a particular group, researchers will investigate documents available about that group—whether they be internal documents such as mission statements, bulletins, manuals, or newsletters, or more public forms like websites, blogs, press releases, and journalistic coverage. All these sources of data can be looked at through the use of methods like discourse analysis and conversation analysis in order to learn about the meaning management taking place in or around the context and participants of interest to the researcher. Sometimes the speeches or films may be the main source of data and the object of inquiry in and of themselves, as is often the case when rhetoricians critically analyze phenomena via speeches or other performances.

Qualitative data include a vast array of the pieces of information that are available for nonstatistical research. The collection, analysis, interpretation, and reporting of these data vary, and each technique and method should be scrutinized for what it is well equipped to deliver, and for what weaknesses or blind spots it may pose for inquiry.

Mark A. Leeman and David R. Novak

See also [Critical Analysis](#); [Interpretative Research](#); [Interviews for Data Gathering](#); [Participant Observer](#); [Quantitative Research, Purpose of](#); [Quantitative Research, Steps for](#); [Textual Analysis](#)

Further Readings

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Mark A. Leeman David R. Novak

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